

Department of Economics
Johns Hopkins University
Baltimore, MD 21218
dedwar65@jh.edu

December 21, 2025

Search Committee
Department of Economics and Finance
Murray State University
Murray, KY
USA

Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I am writing to express my strong interest in the tenure-track Assistant Professor position in the Department of Economics and Finance at Murray State University. I am a Ph.D. candidate in Economics at Johns Hopkins University, advised by Professors Christopher D. Carroll, Nicholas W. Papageorge, and Stelios Fourakis, and I expect to receive my degree in May 2026. My research fields are macroeconomics, wealth and income dynamics, and computational economics.

My research agenda focuses on understanding the determinants of wealth inequality and the mechanisms through which heterogeneity in returns to wealth shapes aggregate outcomes. In my job-market paper, I estimate the degree of heterogeneity in individual portfolio returns using micro-data from the Survey of Consumer Finances and simulate a structural model in which households face idiosyncratic return risk. I show that allowing for persistent heterogeneity in returns substantially improves the model's ability to match the empirical distribution of wealth, offering a tractable way to connect micro-level return dispersion to macroeconomic inequality.

In a second project, I use the Health and Retirement Study to examine the relationship between interpersonal trust and portfolio performance. Building on the literature that finds a hump-shaped relationship between trust and income, I show that a similar relationship holds for individual returns to wealth measured in the HRS data, highlighting a behavioral channel through which social attitudes shape saving and investment outcomes. This work also provides new estimates of the persistent component of returns to net worth, which motivate the calibration of heterogeneity in my structural model.

Murray State University's emphasis on excellent teaching, close faculty–student interaction, and a balanced teacher–scholar model makes it a particularly strong fit for my interests and professional goals. The department's openness to scholars across fields of economics, combined with its expectation of a coherent and promising research agenda, aligns well with my training and approach. I am especially drawn to Murray State's mission as a public, comprehensive university that blends rigorous academic expectations with a strong commitment to undergraduate education.

Teaching. I have experience teaching and supporting courses in *Principles of Macroeconomics*, *Intermediate Macroeconomics*, and quantitative methods. My teaching emphasizes clarity, economic intuition, and the use of data to connect economic theory to real-world outcomes that are meaningful to students. At Murray State, I would be well prepared to teach principles-level courses as well as intermediate macroeconomics and applied electives such as money and banking, economic forecasting,

or statistics, depending on departmental needs. I value student engagement, accessibility, and structured feedback, and I am committed to maintaining high instructional standards across in-person and online formats.

I would be enthusiastic about contributing to the Department of Economics and Finance through teaching, research, and service, and about becoming an active member of the Murray State academic community. Murray State's focus on student learning, collegial faculty culture, and regional engagement make it an environment in which I would be excited to build a long-term academic career.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application further.

Sincerely,

Decory Edwards